

Data Sharing Champion: Unlocking the Power of Data to Advance Cancer Research

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Unlocking the Power of Data to Advance Cancer
Research

Overview

How can we dismantle fragmented data silos to unlock the life-saving potential of shared clinical and genomic data? This critical question was the driving force behind the NCI Office of Data Sharing (ODS) Third Annual Data Sharing Symposium. Bringing together leading experts across academia, government, and industry, the event focused on a shared, transformative mission: transitioning biomedical data from isolated, proprietary assets into a connected, secure public utility designed to accelerate cancer breakthroughs.

The "Why": Connecting Siloed Data for Healthcare Outcomes Improvement

In oncological research, critical insights often remain sequestered within individual institutions or research groups. To bridge these gaps, the symposium explored how to drive a systemic culture shift that actively *"promotes long-term scientific goals"* while maintaining robust, secure confidentiality standards.

However, technological innovation is not a standalone solution. While cutting-edge, privacy-preserving technologies—such as federated learning—allow researchers to perform decentralized collaborative analyses without transferring sensitive raw data, technology only provides the capability. The true catalyst for widespread adoption lies in robust policy frameworks and systemic incentives that align institutional practices with the public good, establishing a seamless *"balance between broad and efficient sharing and the needs of the cancer research and participant communities."*

The "How": Building the Collaborative Ecosystem

To replace isolated silos with a unified, high-performing research network, the symposium outlined three essential pillars of action:

Pillar	Strategic Focus
Fostering a Culture of Shared Purpose	Collaborative initiatives like the ODS Data Jamboree demonstrated that when interdisciplinary teams unite, scientific discovery accelerates. Together, the oncology community is actively dismantling systemic barriers, shifting the paradigm of data sharing from a <i>"perceived barrier to a norm and an expectation for the community."</i>
Establishing Policy and Institutional Incentives	Robust infrastructure must be reinforced by policy mandates and professional incentives. The symposium highlighted the need for funding requirements, data citation standards, and academic credit systems that reward researchers for sharing high-quality datasets, thereby converting policy from a compliance burden into an engine for innovation.
Constructing Interoperable Infrastructure	The scientific community's willingness to collaborate must be supported by harmonized tools. Technical experts are actively building <i>"federated and interoperable"</i> systems to generate standardized, <i>"AI ready" datasets.</i> Utilizing robust, shared platforms, we are establishing the technical foundation needed to securely unite global research efforts.

Further Reading

Learn more about previous symposia on our Data Sharing Hub [Symposia Page](#)

Read more about the Office of Data Sharing mission and activities, including the Data Sharing Symposium, in our publication [“NCI’s Office of Data Sharing Builds Momentum to Advance Cancer Research and Care.”](#)

Be Part of the Future

The insights from this year’s symposium provide a comprehensive blueprint for a future where connected data directly translates into improved clinical outcomes. We invite you to join us as we continue to shape the policy, culture, and technology of cancer research.

Join us on Nov 5-6, 2026, for the Fourth Annual Office of Data Sharing Symposium, “Data to Discovery: Leveraging Cancer Data in the ‘Real World.’” [Register today.](#)

Announcements

NCI Office of Data Sharing Seminar Series

[Registration.](#)

Generalizable Multi-modal AI Approaches to Advance Cancer Care Delivery

Date and Time: July 29, 2026, 12:00 PM – 1:00 PM EDT

Speaker: Julian Hong, MD, MS. Associate Professor, Radiation Oncology. University of California, San Francisco

Description: High level randomized controlled data continues to be lacking in artificial intelligence and machine learning applications in healthcare. This session will review one of the early randomized controlled experiences in healthcare machine learning, focused on the prediction and prevention of unplanned acute care during cancer therapy. The discussion will center on subsequent ongoing NCI-funded efforts in multi-institutional generalizability, integration of wearable device data, and prospective validation studies.

Turn Ideas into Impact: Learn how to participate in two New Prize Challenge Competitions from the NCI Office of Data Sharing

Date and Time: August 12, 2026, 1:00 PM – 2:00 PM EDT

Speakers: Nathan Boyd, Health Scientist Administrator, NCI Office of Data Sharing. Emily Boja, Branch Chief, NCI Office of Data Sharing.

Description: Join the National Cancer Institute (NCI) Office of Data Sharing (ODS) for a pre-submission webinar introducing two new prize competitions: the NCI ODS Community Impact Prize (\$200,000 total prize) and the Pediatric and Adolescent and Young Adults Cancer Data Initiative Innovation Challenge (\$15,000,000 total prize). Learn about each competition's goals, eligibility requirements, submission process, key deadlines. The session will conclude with a live Q&A to address participant questions.

Request for Information: Measuring and Rewarding Scientific Impact. [NOT-OD-26-087.](#)

Biomedical research has increasingly become a collaborative and interdisciplinary enterprise that relies on transparent reporting, rigorous replication, careful interpretation of methods and analyses, and the iterative refinement of scientific knowledge. In recognition of this evolution, NIH seeks public input on the defining features of modern 21st-century science that should be measured, recognized, and incentivized. Responses should be submitted through the [comment form](#) by **August 19, 2026.**

We'd love to hear from you! Contact the ODS team at: nciofficeofdatasharing@mail.nih.gov

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